

Dead Signal

Production Plan

Jharek

Version 1.1 · 2026-07-06

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Version	1.1
Status	Living — active plan from current build to release
Last updated	2026-07-06
Owner	Jharek (production/design/dev)
Supersedes	PLAN.md (the completed M0–M8 AI-removal + battery roadmap — now historical)
Companion docs	PRD · GDD · Technical Design · canon STORY.md

Purpose. The single plan for getting *Dead Signal* from its current shipped-spine state to a polished release: what’s done, what’s left, in what order, how we gate each step, how we test, and how we ship. The [PRD](#) defines *what must be true to ship* (release criteria); this document defines *how we get there*.

Working model. Solo developer. The plan is therefore **dependency- and criteria-driven, not calendar-driven** — milestones are sequenced by what unblocks what, and each has explicit exit criteria. Target dates are the author’s to set against these gates. The one inviolable rule (inherited from PLAN.md): **the game must boot and play at every checkpoint — never leave a broken build between milestones.**

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1. Current state

The playable spine is complete. A player can start, cross Harwick by any of three routes, reach the empty Haven, auto-flow into the Phase 3 investigation, uncover all four truths, and reach either ending — offline, deterministic, with zero API calls. What remains is **polish, the documentation suite, accessibility, localization, and release hardening** — not core construction.

Dimension	Reality
Core game	Shipped: prologue + Phase 3 (4 truth spokes) + finale + 2 endings
Determinism	No AI, no network, no API keys (verified — PLAN.md M4)
Persistence	3 slots, per-slot profiles, forward-compatible save schema
Delivery	Installable PWA + GitHub Pages CI deploy
Docs	In progress: GDD/PRD/DESIGN + this plan done; Audio/Art/Loc/Access queued
Accessibility	Structural advantages in place; option set + audit not yet built
Localization	Not started — blocked on string externalization
Release hardening	Platform matrix pass, spoiler audit, store/distribution decision pending

2. Development status by area

Priority: **P0** ship-blocking · **P1** wanted for a polished launch · **P2** post-launch-ok.

Area	Status	Priority	Notes
Prologue (P1–P2, 3 routes)	Done	P0	Ongoing pacing/HUD polish only
Phase 3 investigation	Done	P0	4 regions, gating, Case File evolution

Finale + endings	Done	P0	Accept/Refuse, recorded per slot
Survival economy + tuning	Done	P0	Centralized knobs; Phase-3 economy an open lever
Encounter resolver + risk tiers	Done	P0	Single source of truth for odds + tags
Case File (board + journal)	Done	P0	Contradictions + evolving questions
Audio engine	Done	P1	Procedural; Signal-distortion cue gated
PWA + deploy	Done	P1	Manifest, icons, iOS meta, Pages CI
Spoiler/canon consistency pass	Ongoing	P0	Standing gate before any release
Documentation suite	In progress	P1	GDD/PRD/DESIGN/Production done; 4 docs left
Expansion v2 (Narrative Depth)	Docs-only pass	P1	Canon ; doc propagation ; content/code a future milestone (M-EXP, §11) — no code exists yet
Accessibility option set	Planned	P1	Text-speed, contrast/scaling, audio-cue visual equiv.
Localization	Planned	P2	Externalize strings first
Mobile platform matrix	Planned	P0	iOS Safari + Android Chrome, installed + in-browser
Distribution/monetization decision	Open	P1	Web-only vs. store wrappers; pricing

3. Roadmap & milestones

The path to release, in dependency order. Each milestone lists its **goal** and **exit criteria** (the gate that says it's done). Milestones can overlap where they don't block each other.

M-P — Polish & Consistency P0 ? *in progress*

- **Goal:** the shipped spine reads as finished — pacing, HUD readability, save/load robustness, mobile presentation, and full spoiler/canon alignment across every public surface.
- **Exit criteria:** a full playthrough per route with zero console errors; no spoiler leaks in README/store/in-game Story (audited vs. STORY.md \$4/\$7); Case File and location labels correct end-to-end; save→reload→resume restores a safe state on all three slots.

M-DOC — Documentation Suite P1 ? *in progress*

- **Goal:** complete the professional doc set.
- **Exit criteria:** GDD , PRD , DESIGN , Production (this doc), then **Audio Bible, Art Bible + SVG wireframes, Localization Plan, Accessibility Plan** — each written to MD source + polished Word/PDF export, indexed in docs/README.md.
- **Sequence (agreed):** Production → Audio → Art+wireframes → Localization → Accessibility.

M-EXP — Expansion v2 (Narrative Depth) P1 ? *code milestone future; docs in progress*

- **Goal:** implement the sanctioned narrative-density pass — Echoes, region sub-stories, the unchosen thread, truth-by-assembly, and the prologue second act — **as authored text + nodes only, no new mechanics** (STORY.md \$9 carve-out). Full deliverable list and staging in §11.
- **Staging (hard gate order):** (1) STORY.md canon **done** → (2) design-doc propagation **in progress** (this edit + GDD/PRD/DESIGN) → (3) content authoring + code integration **future**. This milestone's *code* work does not start until the doc propagation lands; **this pass is DOCS ONLY**.
- **Depends on:** M-P clean (the shipped spine and its truths/gates/endings are the fixed base this layers onto and must not disturb) + doc propagation complete.
- **Exit criteria:** ~14 Echo fragments + 7-face cast authored and wired to the new ECHOES Case File category; ~30 new Phase-3 nodes integrated (region sub-stories, U1 unchosen thread) taking Phase 3 from ~35 → ~65 nodes; S1 truth-by-assembly live (each region truth resolves only after its 2–3 supporting pieces are found); prologue second act (P1–P3) integrated spoiler-safe; every shipped truth, gate, and both endings **unchanged**; loc/all y deltas from the added text logged (§5, §11); full regression bar (§6.1) green.

M-A11Y — Accessibility P1 ?

- **Goal:** deliver the accessibility option set and pass an audit to WCAG 2.2 AA baseline.
- **Depends on:** Accessibility Plan (M-DOC).
- **Exit criteria:** text-speed/instant-reveal option; contrast + scaling verified against the #070707 canvas; a visual equivalent for the Signal audio cue; photosensitivity audit of the distortion effect passed; keyboard-navigable; content/trauma notes surfaced; muted-playable confirmed end-to-end.

M-LOC — Localization P2 ?

- **Goal:** the game is translatable and ships at least one non-English language.

- **Critical path: string externalization** — strings are hardcoded inline in DeadSignal.jsx today; nothing else in loc can start until they're extracted.
- **Depends on:** Localization Plan (M-DOC).
- **Exit criteria:** externalized string catalog; pseudo-loc pass with no truncation/overflow on a phone screen; ≥1 language integrated and LQA'd; culturalization decisions logged for the 143/KIM → ELLIE motifs.

M-RC — Release Candidate P0 ?

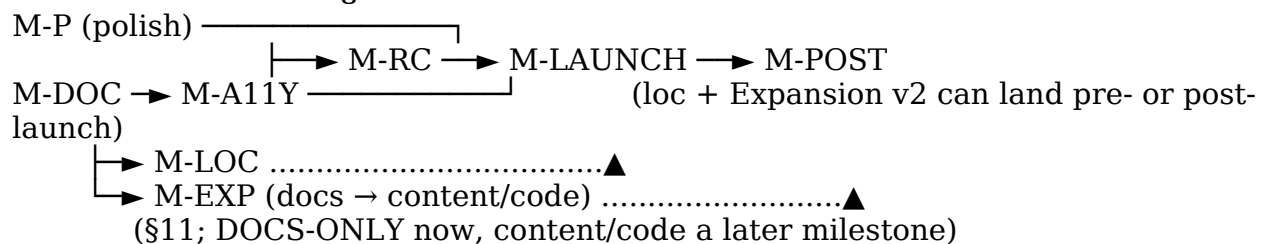
- **Goal:** all PRD P0 release criteria met; the build is a candidate.
- **Depends on:** M-P, plus the platform matrix pass.
- **Exit criteria (from PRD §8):** full arc completable on mobile + desktop, zero console errors, zero network calls; both endings reachable and recorded; save schema round-trips; PWA installs and runs offline on iOS Safari + Android Chrome; core-screen accessibility smoke test passes; **no spoiler leaks; canon consistency pass clean.**

M-LAUNCH — Release P0 ?

- **Goal:** ship.
- **Depends on:** M-RC + the distribution decision (§7, §9).
- **Exit criteria:** tagged release; production deploy green; store/listing (if any) live; launch runbook (§7) executed.

M-POST — Post-launch P2 ?

- **Goal:** support and complete the P1/P2 tracks that didn't gate launch (loc, extra ally).
- **Exit criteria:** rolling — see §8.



4. Scope ledger

The discipline that keeps a solo project shippable. Canonical stop-doing list is STORY.md §9; this formalizes it for production.

In scope (to release)

Polish of the shipped spine; the documentation suite; accessibility option set; the mobile platform matrix; spoiler/canon hardening; release + deploy. Localization is in scope but may land as a fast-follow (P2).

Expansion v2 (Narrative Depth) — in scope as authored content, staged after the docs (M-EXP, §11). The sanctioned narrative-density pass: Echoes, region sub-stories, the

unchosen thread (U1), truth-by-assembly (S1), the prologue second act (P1-P3). This is **authored text + node work only** — no new mechanics — under the STORY.md §9 carve-out. The current pass is **docs-only**; content authoring + code integration is a separate later milestone that can land pre- or post-launch.

Out of scope (explicitly not doing)

- More encounter types, more random exploration beats, more Haven flavor text, more survival mechanics — the investigation layer and regions are the game.
- **More combat depth** — combat's meaning is delivered in Phase 3, not through mechanics.
- Any return to live-LLM / networked narration — determinism is a product pillar.
- Multiplayer, social, accounts, cloud saves.
- **The Expansion v2 §9 carve-out is narrowly scoped**: it sanctions *narrative density* (authored text + nodes), **not** new systems. New combat/survival/encounter mechanics remain out of scope even during M-EXP. Restraint (STORY.md §4) is the ceiling on the pass.

Held open (documented, not in this pass)

- **U2 — a dedicated citizen-shelter region for the unchosen** (a thematic region holding no new truth). Specified in STORY.md §5 so it can be picked up later without re-planning; **not scheduled for M-EXP**.
- **X1 — ending-texture shading** (the same two ending screens shaded by what the player recovered). Documented (STORY.md §5); **not in this pass**.

Cut (built then removed — do not resurrect without cause)

- **Real-time wall-clock day gates** (Lifeline-style) — designed, built, dropped for smooth prologue→Phase 3 flow; scaffolding left dormant behind ?gates (STORY.md changelog #8).
 - **Live Claude/API narration** — removed in favor of authored content (PLAN.md M4).
 - The standalone phase2_complete “to be continued” screen — culled; the prologue auto-flows.
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5. Risk register

Likelihood (L) / Impact (I): H/M/L. Ordered by severity.

#	Risk	L	I	Mitigation	Trigger to act
R1	Spoiler leak into public copy breaks the mystery	M	H	Spoiler discipline codified (GDD §4.5); public-copy audit	Any new store/marketing/Story-screen copy

					vs. STORY. md is an M- RC gate	
R2	Narrative/ canon drift across docs + build	M		H	STORY.md single source of truth; standing consistency pass; docs defer to canon	Any edit touching story or a doc
R3	iOS Safari PWA/audio quirks (unlock fails, standalone bugs)	M		M	Existing unlock/resu me handling in audio.js; explicit device matrix in M- RC	Any audio/PWA change; new iOS version
R4	Localizatio n debt (hardcoded strings) grows	H		M	Externalize early (M- LOC critical path); treat as a refactor, not a feature	Before committing to any launch language set
R5	Solo-dev bandwidth stalls burndown	H		M	Phased docs; hard non- goals (\$4); polish over expansion; criteria- gated milestones	Any milestone slipping without a blocker
R6	Save- schema regression corrupts progress	L		H	Forward- compatible defaults; save round- trip in the QA bar; migrations tested	Any change to snapshot/pr ofile shape
R7	Scope creep re-opens “done”	M		M	Scope ledger (\$4); changes to	Any request to add mechanics/c

	systems			cut/out items need a written reason	ombat
R8	Distribution/monetization undecided blocks launch	M	M	Decide before M-LAUNCH (\$9); web-only is a valid default	Entering M-RC
R9	DeadSignal.jsx size slows iteration/onboarding	M	L	Optional data-block extraction (DESIGN \$13); no architecture change	When navigation cost bites
R10	Expansion v2 scope growth erodes the restraint pillar (Phase 3 ~35 → ~65 nodes)	M	M	Sanctioned carve-out is narrative density only , not mechanics (STORY.md \$9); node budget capped at ~2×; U2/X1 held open (\$4); truths/gates/endings frozen; restraint (\$4) is the ceiling and an M-EXP exit gate	Any M-EXP item proposing a new mechanic, a new truth, or nodes beyond ~2×
R11	Loc + all load grows with ~2× Phase-3 text (Echoes +	M	M	Size M-LOC/M-AllY against the larger post-	Committing to a launch language set or the externalizati

sub-stories)

Expansion string set, not today's; author
Expansion strings *before* string externalizati on commits, or plan a second extraction pass; all y (text-speed/contr ast) already covers new text
on refactor while M-EXP content is unwritten

6. QA & playtest protocol

Determinism makes QA tractable: outcomes are reproducible, so a failure is a real bug, not variance.

6.1 Standing regression bar (every release)

- **Full start→ending playthrough per route** (hospital / metro / route 9) with **zero console errors** and **zero network calls**.
- **Both endings** reachable and correctly recorded (profile.ending).
- **Save round-trip**: save → reload → resume restores a safe decision point; legacy saves migrate.
- **Production build** compiles clean.

6.2 Automated QA (the established methodology)

The project has a proven browser-automation QA harness (see the worktree PLAYTESTING.md; **action item: promote it into docs/ / repo root so it's a first-class asset**). Recipes, verified against source: - **Dev flags**: ?debug enables GATE_BYPASS + a skip (dev) button + an audio diagnostic overlay + choice-cap warnings (also on in any Vite dev build); ?gates activates the dormant real-time day gates for resting-screen/countdown testing. - **8× time compression** — a setTimeout shim to run beat pacing fast without touching Date.now. - **Message logger** — a MutationObserver over .ds-chat to capture streamed lines. - **Auto-driver** — clicks real story choices (button.cb.choice-btn inside .ds-choices-pane), with novelty/steered-walker policies; stall detection; case-file/menu recovery. - **Gate fast-forward** — stub Date.now forward to skip the 17-min

DAY_GATE_MS countdown, then restore immediately (a doctored clock poisons autosave timestamps).

6.3 Manual playtest matrix

Axis	Coverage
Routes	Hospital · Metro · Route 9 (each: ignore-power run + engaged run)
Economy	Verify ignore-power scrapes to the intended low; engaged play stays survivable
Platforms	iOS Safari, Android Chrome — installed PWA and in-browser
Save/load	All 3 slots; interrupt mid-leg; resume; delete-confirm flow
Endings	Accept and Refuse; replay for the other ending; 100% accrual across runs

6.4 Content gates (pre-release)

- **Canon consistency pass** against STORY.md (no contradictions). (*When M-EXP content lands, this gate also verifies the Echoes/sub-stories/S1 assembly against the \$2/\$3/\$5/\$6 canon, and that no shipped truth, gate, or ending changed.*)
- **Spoiler audit** of every public surface (README, browser/demo shell, in-game Story page). (*The prologue second act and Echoes must stay spoiler-safe: no Echoes and no answers in the prologue.*)
- **Accessibility smoke test** (readable, pausable, muted-playable, no-twitch).

7.